

Back up everything

From syncing to cloud backups to software options and hardware configurations

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We're almost drowning in the data that we create. This raises two important issues: how do you deal with keeping your data synced across multiple devices (portable or otherwise) and how do you keep your data backed up to prevent any unfortunate loss of information either due to a system failure, physical damage or theft. In this feature, we'll deal with solutions to both these issues.

Sync

The leaders on this front are devices from Apple Inc. If you're using an iPhone and iMac (desktop or laptop) you should immediately be upgrading your operating system (if you haven't) to benefit from the iCloud service, which is offered for free. It not only keeps your data, but also applications, settings and calendar all synced and backed up on the cloud,



iCloud: Hassle-free sync

without any effort on your part. Of course, you might have your own concerns about handing your data to Apple, but if you're okay with that, it might be reason enough for you to make the switch.

If you're looking for an option that works for all operating systems, here's

another option. And you have to be living under a rock to not have heard about this one – the awesome syncing service, Dropbox. It's available at <https://www.dropbox.com/> and gives you a one-step way to keep your files synced across computers and devices. The service offers 2.5 GB free, post which there are paid options and other referral schemes to avail more space. It works on Windows, Linux, Mac, iPhone, Android and even BlackBerry. So if you're using devices from various vendors and want a dead simple way to keep your important data available to you at any time, give this service a spin.

If you're an Ubuntu user, then the Ubuntu One (<https://one.ubuntu.com/>) service provides a similar functionality as the Dropbox service mentioned above. In addition to 5 GB of free space, it provides useful add-ons like built-in music streaming, and has clients for Windows, other Linux distros and even Android.

A surprising amount of our interaction with the computer happens with the browser these days, and it's equally important to keep our browsing history, add-ons, settings and if possible even open tabs in sync. Imagine leaving your browser open with certain tabs at your work, and then coming back home, opening your browser on another computer and finding yourself exactly where you left. While previously there were patchy solutions available, with Firefox Sync all of this is seamless.

In the Google ecosystem, you use your single Google login credentials to access all your email, calendar, contacts and documents anywhere on any device provided there's a working internet connection. With the new Google Chrome Sign In feature you get a similar functionality as Firefox Sync. Google also provides the Free Google Sync (<http://www.google.com/sync/>) services

for free push email, calendar, contacts and even notes across a range of devices from Windows/Mac/Linux to all mobile platforms including our old and often neglected friend, the Symbian S60.

Most of the sync services use some form or the other of internet connectivity and back up data on their own data centres. If you're either paranoid about handing over your data or simply work in situations where you don't have access to the internet all the time, a simple and very effective solution would be to carry your data with you. With 32 GB pen drives available for well under ₹1,500, you could give this solution a try. You can geek it up by installing a Live Linux distribution like Ubuntu on it and you have your own computer with your applications, settings and data wherever you go. Follow this guide <https://wiki.ubuntu.com/LiveUsbPendrivePersistent> to have your own system with you always.

Back up

The first step is accumulating all data including your online data locally. If you're in the Apple iCloud system, then you're already done. If you're using Google services for email and documents you can do the following. Flip over a few pages in the magazine itself to read how to backup other social media data.

- For Google Docs, open the documents page, select any one document. Click on the small arrow next to More, then click on "Download" in the pop up. Select the "All Items" tab, select the format you want and all your data would be available to you in a single zip file.
- For Gmail, sign in and click on "Settings" (the cog wheel icon), go to the "Forwarding and POP/IMAP" tab. Over here, select "Enable POP for all mail (even mail that's already been downloaded)" and click "Save changes". Now pick your favorite client (Outlook, ThunderBird or